

"Don Juan in Sicily" and "The Handsome Antonio" are outstanding serio-comic works of recent years).

Examples could be multiplied at will. The weekly magazines are produced according to a formula that includes the article on current political news along with the short story, the society column (often written with obvious tongue-in-cheek) along with the foreign correspondent's reportage or, say, the "human-interest" record of a current trial. These weekly magazines are in rotogravure, about one third of their space occupied by very large and in varying degrees eye-catching or even "shocking" photographs. *Il Mondo* is the most sedate of them, but it has the same general format; and it is in this magazine that Italians, for instance, can read fairly frequently the prose of the nation's venerable philosopher Benedetto Croce. This seems on the whole a sign of vitality.

These magazines, and the "third pages," are then, in spite of a certain flamboyant appearance, written products: the use they make of language, the tradition they belong to, are literary. To give one example, the editor (or to use the Italian terminology, the "director") of the extremely popular *L'Europeo* is Arrigo Benedetti, himself a writer of very subtle works of fiction, a man whose origins are in the literary *avant garde*. Practically all Italian writers are connected with one or another of the weeklies and dailies, or with several of them. Eugenio Montale, regarded by many as the leading Italian poet, and by the philistines as the very essence of the ivory tower, is permanently employed by the daily *Corriere della Sera*. The "third page" breaks through the distinction between *avant garde* and popular writing; and taking an optimistic view of things, one cannot think of a better training ground for a type of writing that is both respectably artistic and capable of reaching a wide audience.

The danger, of course, is that the necessary pursuit of such more practical and ephemeral forms of litera-

ture may leave writers little time for the more durable and traditional ones, like the novel. Besides, there is a tendency now in Italy, as everywhere among the younger writers of "high-brow" origin, to take a sort of pride in commercial success; it is a kind of *revanche* against the accusations of ivory-tower obscurity and lack of practical sense which beset them in the past. In Italy this has been more obvious than elsewhere because it has coincided with the restitution of freedom to the writers to handle whatever themes they please, and with the consequent eagerness with which some of them devoted themselves (in stories, films, and most especially in the weekly magazines) to a certain type of "shocking" exposure of realities. The spectacles offered by their age and country were, to be sure, shocking enough and justified them fully; it is regrettable if those manners become mannerisms. But perhaps the "shocking" qualities of certain themes and techniques are the necessary spurious elements without which a literature remains unadvertised and unknown abroad. This is confirmed by the type of success that the recent Italian novels and films have had; Moravia is a serious artist, but there is no doubt that his best-selling success began the day people found out that his eighth novel was the autobiography of a prostitute. There are similar situations in the motion pictures; "Bitter Rice" was advertised, at least in Hollywood, on the basis of the heroine's figure and attire, and it achieved astounding commercial results; while a considerably better film like Germi's "Path of Hope" passed almost unnoticed.

As things now stand, the notion of literature as an art is far from having disappeared in Italy; but it may be seriously threatened by everyday hand-to-mouth necessities. We shall have new novels from Italy if writers have time to write them. As long as they do, it seems fairly certain that such novels will remain the more serious part of their activity. In fact, the echo of whatever international success these writers are having does not seem to represent a danger. In Rome last summer, in the offices of *Il Mondo*, I remember talking one evening with Ennio Flaiano and mentioning several reviews of his book in English which I had read; one of them, in an English magazine, especially enthusiastic. But since it happened that I had flown in from Los Angeles practically the day before, Flaiano seemed more interested to hear about Hollywood than about himself. As for the reviews of his book, he apparently had never seen or heard of them.

LITERARY I.Q. ANSWERS

1. "Tom Jones," by Fielding. 2. Nora Helmer, in "A Doll's House," by Ibsen. 3. Andrew Undershaft, in "Major Barbara," by Shaw. 4. Harpagon, in "The Miser," by Molière. 5. Hermann, in "The Queen of Spades," by Pushkin. 6. Silas Lapham, in "The Rise of Silas Lapham," by Howells. 7. Isabel Archer, in "The Portrait of a Lady," by Henry James. 8. "Richard Cory," by E. A. Robinson. 9. "Silas Marner," by George Eliot. 10. Antonio, in "The Merchant of Venice," by Shakespeare.

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